

Vocabulary Instruction — Classroom Cheat Sheet

Science of Reading • grades 3–5 focus • prepared for Alyssa via CIRBUS • 2026-07-23

The big idea: Vocabulary is one of the five reading pillars (National Reading Panel). Words stick through **rich, active, repeated** use — not lists & definitions. Aim for **5–8 high-value words a week**, met many times, many ways.

1. Pick Tier 2 words **Beck & McKeown**

High-utility words across many texts, rare in speech.

Choose 5–8 from a read-aloud (e.g. *reluctant, analyze, contrast*). Skip known Tier 1; teach Tier 3 as needed in content.

2. Student-friendly explanations

Definitions confuse; plain language sticks.

Explain in everyday words + example + non-example. “Reluctant = you don’t really want to... like leaving a warm bed.”

3. Many encounters, spaced out

One exposure isn’t enough.

Have students hear, say, read & write each word across days and contexts. Keep bringing words back.

4. Make them USE it **robust**

Active use beats re-reading definitions.

Sentence stems, “is this an example of ___?”, partner talk, act it out, quick writes with the word.

5. Marzano’s 6 steps **routine**

A repeatable teach-and-revisit cycle.

Explain → restate in own words → draw it → then discuss, compare, and play review games over time.

6. Teach morphology

Word parts unlock unseen words.

Grade 4: affixes (*re-, un-, -tion, -able*) & roots (*port=carry* → import, portable). Start from a known word, grow the family.

7. Pre-teach before reading

Front-loading key words boosts comprehension.

Teach the few words a student truly needs to follow the passage — not every hard word.

8. Word-learning strategies

Builds independent word learners.

Model: use context clues → break the word into parts → check the guess fits the sentence.

9. Map relationships **Frayer**

Depth, not just a label.

Semantic maps, synonym/antonym sorts, semantic gradients (hot → warm → cool), or a Frayer 4-square.

10. Read aloud & talk words

Rich texts expose sophisticated words in context.

Read above their level; pause to notice, define, and reuse “juicy” words in discussion.

11. Word wall + notebooks

Visible, ongoing reference & ownership.

Build a wall students add to; personal vocab journals with meaning, a sentence, and a sketch.

12. Word consciousness & games

Curiosity + play drive wide word growth.

Word of the day, charades, “word wizard” box for words spotted in the wild; pair with lots of independent reading.

13. Support multilingual learners **ELLs**

Home-language links speed learning.

Use cognates, visuals, translated terms & sample sentences; practice across reading, writing, speaking, listening (Colorín Colorado).

References: National Reading Panel (2000) / U.S. Dept. of Ed. LINCS — lincs.ed.gov/profile-363 • Beck, McKeown & Kucan, *Bringing Words to Life* (2013) — eric.ed.gov/?id=ED579798 • Marzano’s Six Steps — ascd.org/el/articles/six-steps-to-better-vocabulary-instruction • Reading Rockets, *Vocabulary in Practice & Morphology* (Shanahan) — readingrockets.org • The Reading League (Kappus, 2024) — thereadingleague.org • 95 Percent Group — 95percentgroup.com • NWEA — nwea.org/blog • ASHA (2023) — pubs.asha.org • Colorín Colorado, *12 Tips for ELL Vocabulary* — colorincolorado.org

One-page quick reference — reply with “REQUEST: your topic” for more. Built via CIRBUS for Alyssa.